



**University of
Nottingham**

UK | CHINA | MALAYSIA

Assessments and Marking

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What's all this about?

- Assessments and mark release can be a stressful time
- The best way to overcome this is to understand how everything works and what to expect
- This is part of the NSS → Are marking criteria clear, and is marking and assessment fair?

Marking criteria != mark schemes





What's all this about?

- We will be covering:
 - How we mark in UK universities compared to elsewhere
 - The process in Computer Science
 - Are year 2 and 3 harder?
 - What does an exams officer do?
 - How we write and implement mark schemes
 - Would we consider raising or lowering a mark?
 - What to do if you're unhappy about something?



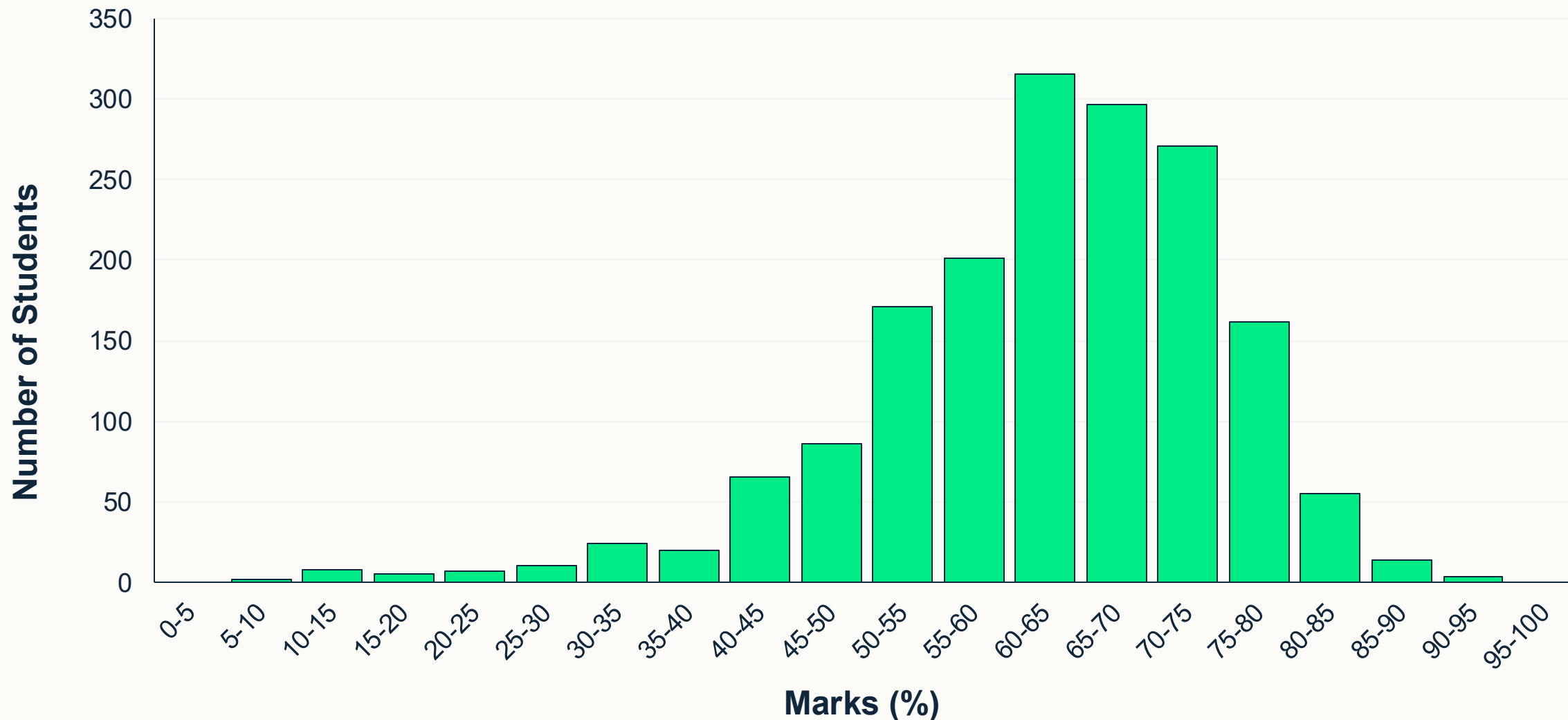
Does it get harder?

- In terms of the *kind* of assessments you will take, there is little difference between year 1 and later years of your degree
- The topics get more advanced, but you are building on a stronger foundation
- Assessments may feel a bit different:
 - Year 1 contains a higher proportion of formative assessments
 - This means later years your marks may trend downwards a bit
 - Year 2+ contributes towards your degree award
 - This may make it feel like every assessment mark matters more than it does in reality



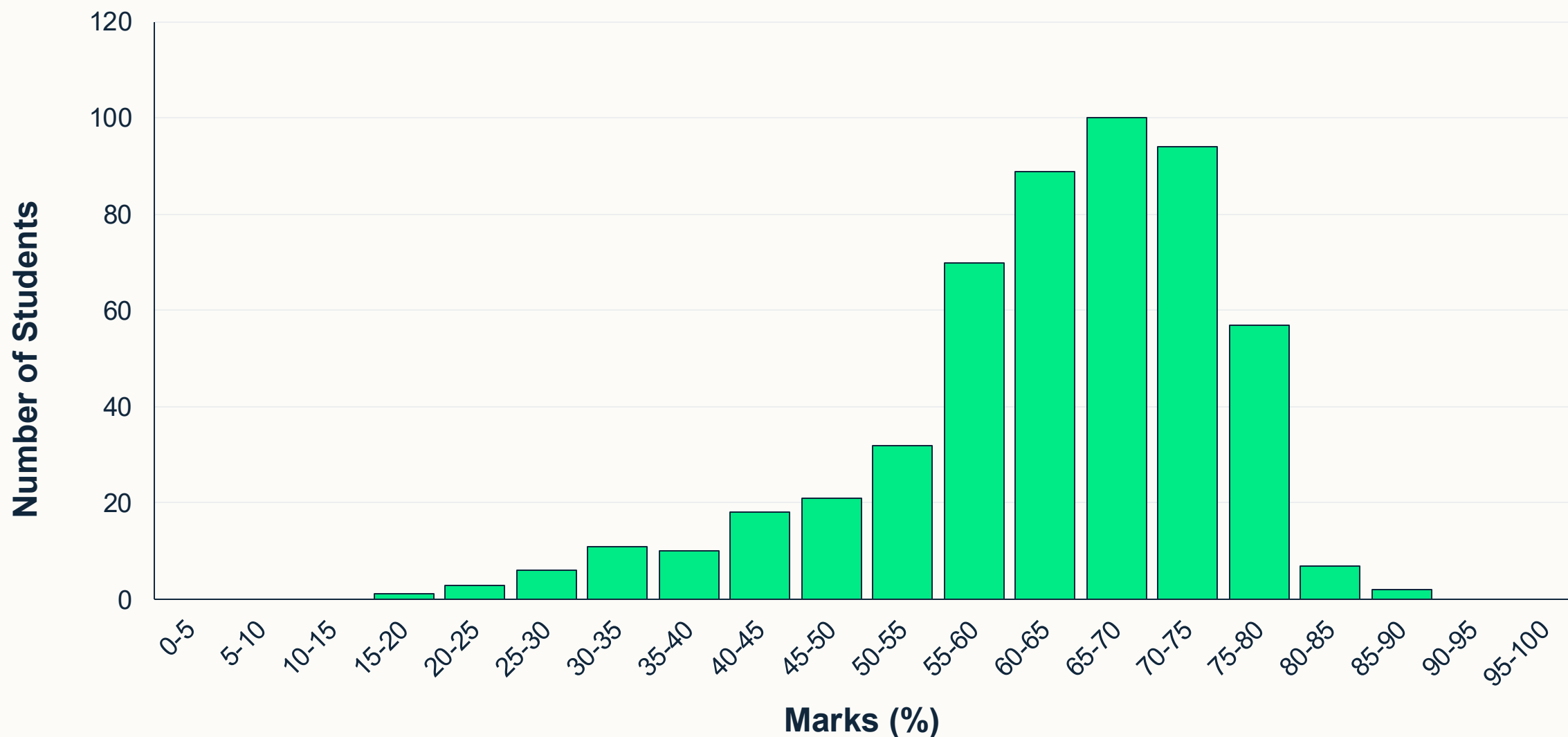
Marks for 1700 students on COMP3006

Computer Security 2015-2024





Degree averages for 500 BSc award students 2022-2024

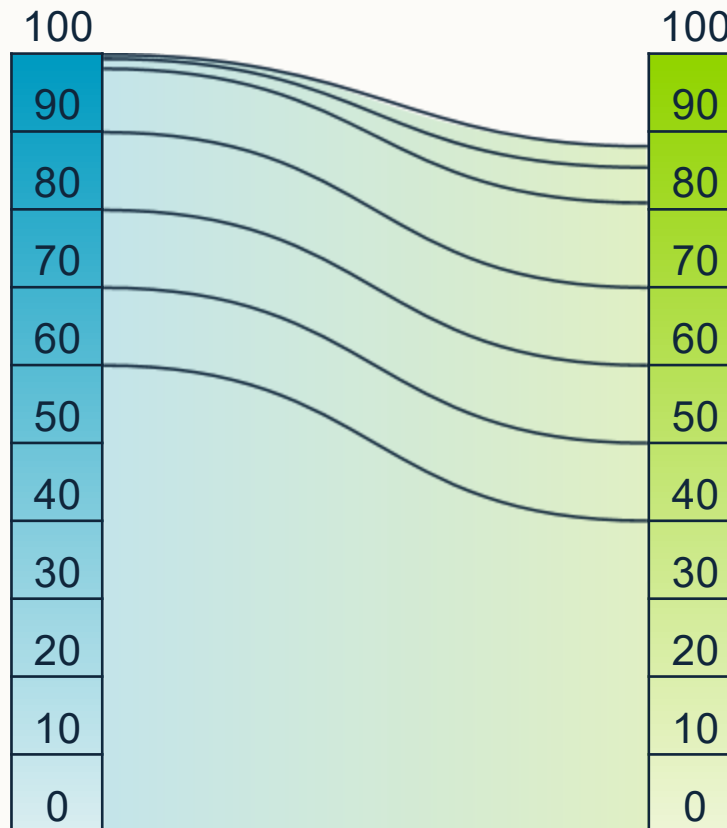




UK vs International Marking

US System

Grade	Percentage	GPA
A+	97–100%	4.0
A	93–96%	3.9
A–	90–92%	3.7
B+	87–89%	3.3
B	83–86%	3.0
B–	80–82%	2.7
C+	77–79%	2.3
C	73–76%	2.0
C–	70–72%	1.7
D+	67–69%	1.3
D	63–66%	1.0
D–	60–62%	0.7
F	0–59%	0.0



UK System

Grade	Percentage
First Class	70–100%
Second Class Division One	60–69%
Second Class Division Two	50–59%
Third Class	40–49%
Fail	0–40%

90% – 100%: Exceptional
80% – 89 %: Outstanding
70% – 79 %: Excellent
60% – 69 %: Good
50% – 59%: Satisfactory
40% – 49 %: Unsatisfactory
39% – 0 %: Fail



UK vs International Marking

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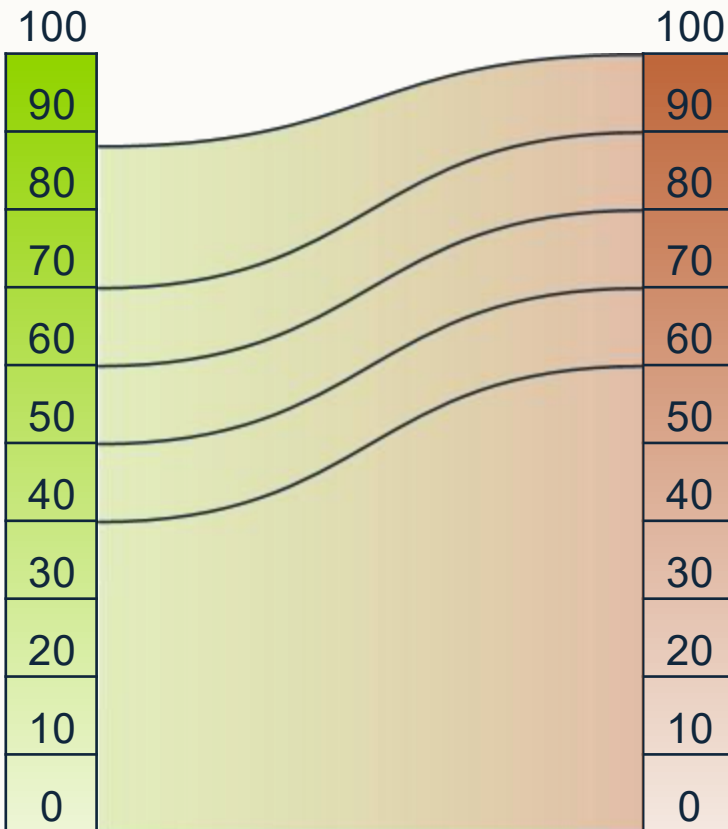
70% – 80 %: Excellent

60% – 70 %: Good

50% – 60%: Satisfactory

40% – 49 %: Unsatisfactory

39% – 0 %: Fail



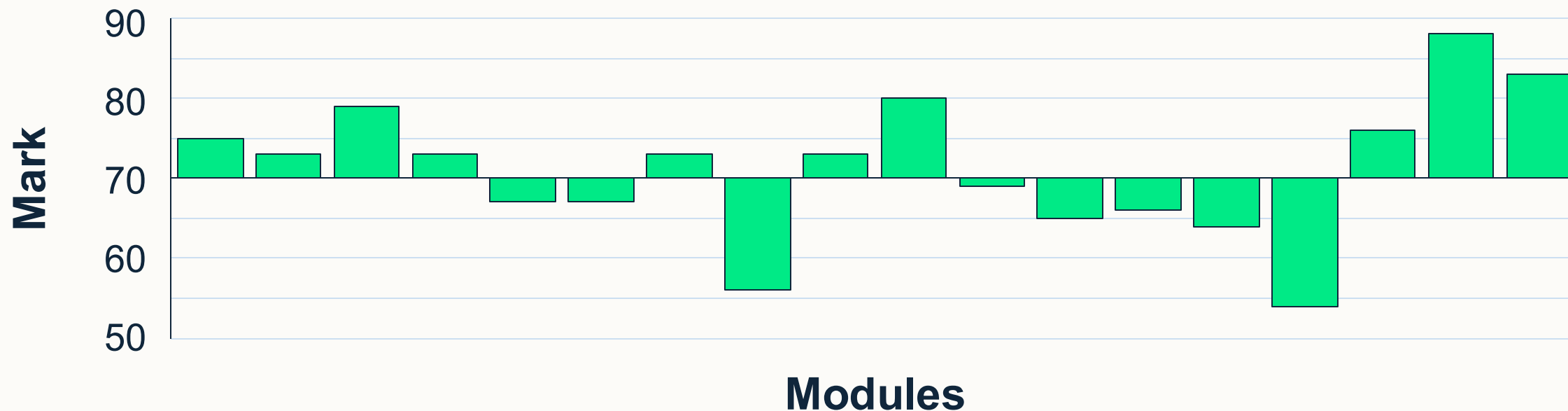
China System

Percentage	GPA
90–100%	4.0
80–89%	3.0–3.9
70–79%	2.0–2.9
60–69%	1.0–1.9
0–60%	0.0–1.0



Why won't you award 100%?

- We will, but no-one achieves this!
- Mark schemes are designed such that higher marks are cumulatively harder to obtain
- No one is good at everything

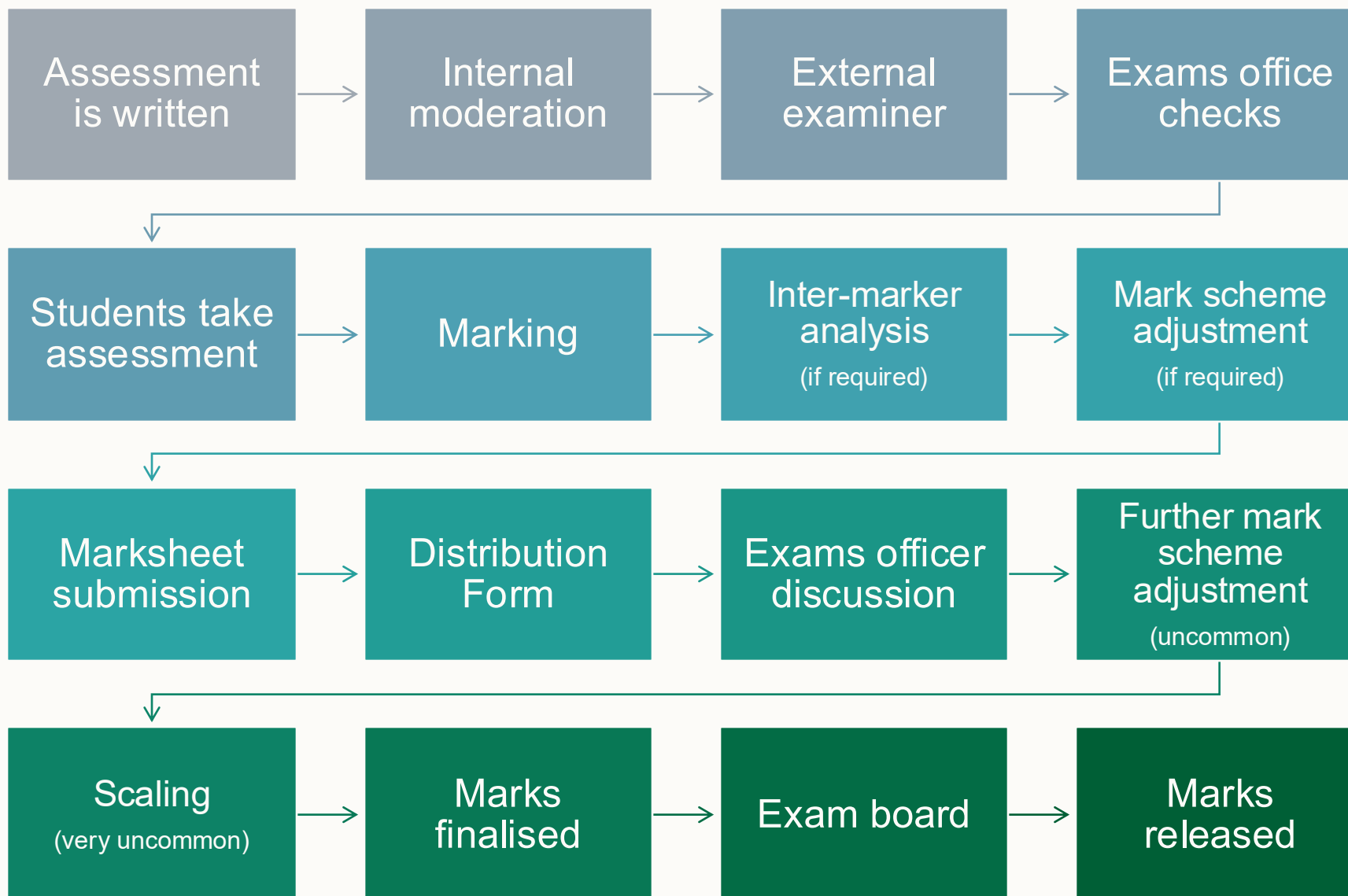




How Marking Works



The (actual) Assessment Process





Mark Scheme Example COMP3006

Recently your organisation has been receiving reports of an increased number of phishing emails sent to staff. You have been tasked with ensuring that the organisation's network remains secure against these threats. Describe what measures you might take to mitigate the risk from phishing emails, and justify them.

[7 Marks]



Mark Scheme Example COMP3006

(1 mark) for any correct answer with a reasonable justification.

Max (4 marks) for easy items + (2 marks) for intermediate items + (1 marks) for a very advanced topic.

Basic: User training, Heuristic antivirus, Software updates, Email filtering, Web filtering.

Intermediate: Remote backups, endpoint detection, ML anomaly detection, firewall restrictive policy, network segmentation

Advanced: TLS deep packet inspection, replacing internal email with SaaS / messengers. Restricted use of email clients for admin accounts, group policy restricted browsers for webmail



Bin	Frequency
[0, 2]	14
(2, 4]	0
(4, 6]	0
(6, 8]	0
(8, 10]	1
(10, 12]	1
(12, 14]	2
(14, 16]	10
(16, 18]	13
(18, 20]	26
(20, 22]	46
(22, 24]	21
(24, 26]	44
(26, 28]	50
(28, 30]	35
(30, 32]	31
(32, 34]	4
(34, 36]	14



Moderation of Marking

- Moderation is an oversight process conducted by another academic
 - At least 50% of a module is moderated
 - All exams are moderated
- Everything is documented, and can be revisited in the case of queries or issues later



Moderation of Marking

Convenor documents:

- Who was involved in marking?
- Were any markers PhD students?
- How were markers distributed over questions?
- Were a substantial number of marks altered after marking?

Moderator checks a selection of submissions across the range of marks

- Has the mark scheme been **applied fairly** and consistently?
- Does the marking reflect the quality of the answers provided?
- Is marking **consistent** between markers?
- Have **all questions** been marked in all cases?
- Are mark totals correct?



Exams Officers

**You can basically
email any of us**

- There are three exams officers:
 - Michael Pound – UG
 - Alex Turner – PGT
 - Jamie Twycross – Data and Processes
- We are responsible for overseeing all assessments, chairing the exam boards, dealing with marking and moderation issues
- We are responsible for progression and award decisions
- If there are problems with e.g. a coursework, we are usually involved
- We also uphold academic integrity – that assessments aren't too easy or too difficult



Do we “change” marks?

- Marks are changed rarely, and *very* carefully
- It's important to know that this can be used to both increase or decrease marks
- We have several options we *could* use:
 1. Take no action – by far the most common

Perhaps the cohort is small, the assessment format is new and a little unpredictable. We can learn from this and improve next year.



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 2. Re-weighting of parts of an assessment e.g. an exam question

Performance on a single question was notably over or under where we would expect, suggests an issue with how that question was pitched or written



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 3. Adjustments to a specific marker or group

For example, the cohort was assessed in two groups, and technical issues occurred with one of the two groups only



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 3. Adjustments to a specific marker or group
 4. Moving or otherwise scaling marks of the entire cohort

An assessment has produced a distribution far outside what we would consider acceptable, and we have found no way to overcome this via e.g. adaptations to the mark scheme



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Such changes are scrutinized first by exams officers, then in the exam board, then reported to the University, accepted by the external examiners, and reported to students



**But what if there's
been a mistake?**



Error vs Academic Judgement

- Most queries that I see about marks are disagreements around **academic judgement**, rather than an **error** in marking.

A **procedural error** is a mistake during marking. This might include a question not being spotted and marked at the end of an exam, or an arithmetic error when totaling the marks.

A query around **Academic Judgement** is a disagreement between the student and the school / an individual academic about the merits of a piece of work. E.g. “I put lots of time in and this is worth 80+%” or “I definitely covered that topic”



Appeals and Academic Judgement

- The university does not consider academic judgement to be grounds for an appeal of a mark:
 - (b) Matters of academic judgement of a School Board of Examiners or individual. The student **will not be permitted to argue the academic merits of their work**. The student's assertion that the result unfairly reflects the merit of their work or their ability is not a ground of appeal.
- Consider that:
 - You haven't taught the course
 - You haven't written and seen the mark scheme
 - You haven't seen 300 other attempts at this work



What if you think something is wrong?

- Feel free to **use the new query form**, and if you feel something needs looking at more closely, **contact an exams officer**
- Student reps will also be able to talk to exams officers on behalf of you or a group of students
- Asking for more clarity, a bit more feedback, or a more detailed breakdown of where you tripped up, this is all reasonable
- Asking for more marks is **not a thing**



Things To Do

- Try to remain **calm** – Mark release can be worrying time for some students but reflect that marks on an individual assessment are likely to affect a small fraction of 1% of your degree.
 - For example, a student who scores 10% lower than they were hoping on the Security coursework will see their degree change by -0.2%, which almost certainly be rounded back
- Please be **patient** – For example I receive 10-15 queries for my module of 300 students within a few hours of a mark release, as well as queries in my role as exams officer
- Be **polite**.



Things to Avoid

- Try to avoid comparing your work with peers:

“I looked at others’ submissions and we wrote the same thing, but I scored lower”

- Avoid blaming your degree average on one assessment:

“I need one more mark in this module otherwise I won’t get a first.”

- Do not assume your performance will be identical in every subject over your degree
- **Do not be rude.**



Conclusions

- The second year may *feel* harder, but you're all CS experts now!
- No one nails every assessment every time
- There are rigorous processes in the school to make sure marks are fair and correct
- Where marks are wildly off, we may take steps to balance to make things fair across all students regardless of their module choice
- We are only human! If you ask for more feedback or think there might have been a mistake, it is fine to ask
- Please be polite and patient, we are working as quickly as we can!
- If in doubt, reach out to an exams officer: Mike, Jamie or Alex.

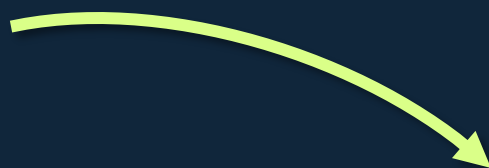


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Thank you

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